

PREMIUM SOLVED WORKBOOK

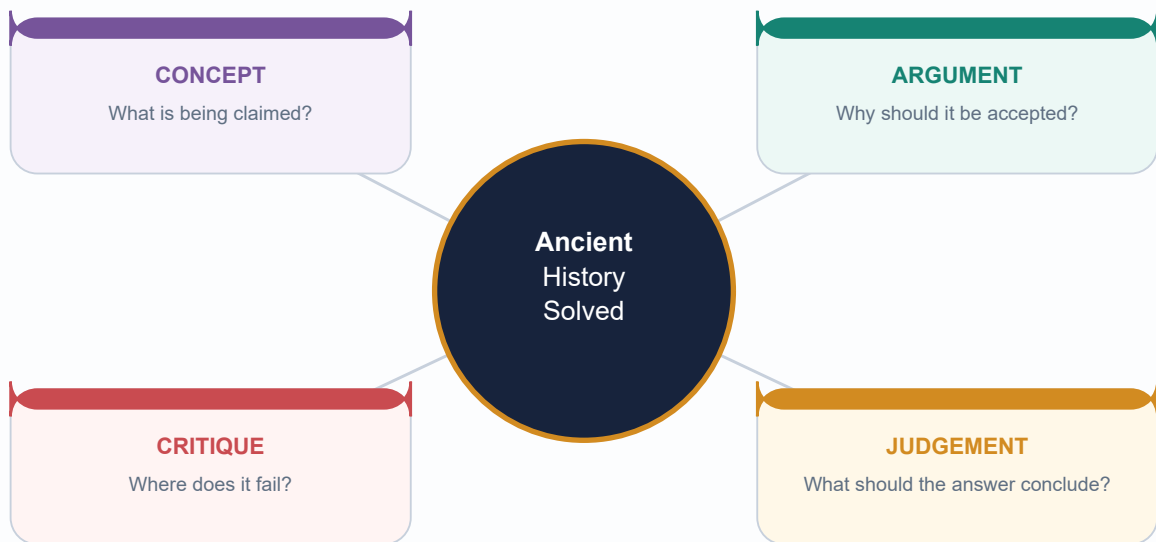
Ancient History 07 - Solved Practice Workbook

The Aryan Problem and Identity of Aryan Culture

Audited 2018-2026 PYQ scope; provisional keys clearly labelled

Strict hard/remedial MCQ key rotation: A -> B -> C -> D

Generated 13 August 2026 | Approval status: PENDING USER APPROVAL



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Verified PYQ Audit and Scope

Prelims + GS-I
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KEY DATA

Year	Stage/question	Relevance	Key status
2026	Prelims Series A Q10, Rigvedic irrigation/wells/draught power	Early Vedic ecology and material vocabulary	Provisional local Series-A key
2026	Prelims Series A Q13, Vedic river names	Textual geography	Provisional local Series-A key
2026	Prelims Series A Q20, <i>kshetra-patni</i>	Vedic textual vocabulary	Provisional local Series-A key
2023	Mains GS-I Q11, Vedic society/religion and persistence	Cultural profile	Exact local official paper
2024	Mains GS-I Q1, Rig-to-Later Vedic social/economic change	Transition and identity	Exact local official paper

STATIC THEORY

- **FACT:** No direct Aryan-origin/migration PYQ appears in the audited repository routing ledgers for 2018-2026. Five closely relevant Vedic-culture questions are included because the user requested all relevant verified questions for the complete package.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. "Provisional key" is not described as an official final UPSC key.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: An adjacent PYQ is labelled a direct Aryan-origin question.

CORRECT: Scope and ownership are stated transparently.

HIGH

Solved Prelims PYQ - 2026 Series A Q10: Rigvedic Irrigation

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STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Consider the statements that irrigation from wells allowed agriculture to expand into the Punjab-Haryana plains and that draught-animal power was used to draw water. Which information support/supports them?

- 1. The Rig Veda refers to *ashma chakra* (stone pulley wheel) and *ahava* (strapped wooden pails) for drawing water.
- 2. The Rig Veda mentions implements such as axe and sickle.
- 3. Oxen had been used before the Rig Veda for ploughing and pulling carts.
- - (A) 1 and 2 only
- - (B) 1, 2 and 3
- - (C) 1 and 3 only
- - (D) 3 only

- **PROVISIONAL LOCAL SERIES-A KEY: C - 1 and 3 only**

- **Explanation:** Information 1 directly supports well-based lifting technology. Information 3 supplies the prior draught-animal capability relevant to lifting and agricultural work. Information 2 establishes tools for cultivation but does not support the specific propositions about wells and animal-powered water lifting.

- **Evidence caution:** The question establishes that agriculture and water management were known; it does not overturn pastoral predominance or prove a large canal-irrigation state.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Early Vedic agriculture was present, not dominant in the later agrarian-state sense.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A sickle proves the mode of lifting water from wells.

CORRECT: It supports harvesting, not the specific water-lifting claim.

HIGH

Solved Prelims PYQ - 2026 Series A Q13: Vedic Rivers

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STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Which pairs of ancient and modern river names are correctly matched?

- 1. Vitasta - Chenab
- 2. Asikni - Jhelum
- 3. Parushni - Ravi
- 4. Yavyavati - Beas

-- (A) 1 and 2

-- (B) 3 and 4

-- (C) 3 only

-- (D) 4 only

- **PROVISIONAL LOCAL SERIES-A KEY: C - 3 only**

- **Explanation:** Vitasta is Jhelum, not Chenab; Asikni is Chenab, not Jhelum; Parushni is Ravi. Beas is Vipasha, so Yavyavati-Beas is not accepted. Therefore only pair 3 is correct.

- **Evidence caution:** River identifications reconstruct textual geography; they do not identify the language or ethnicity of every archaeological settlement along those rivers.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Vitasta-Jhelum; Asikni-Chenab; Parushni-Ravi; Vipasha-Beas.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: A familiar north-western river is matched by geographical proximity rather than the textual name.

CORRECT: Memorize the precise pairs.

HIGH

Solved Prelims PYQ - 2026 Series A Q20: Kshetra-Patni

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STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** In which text does the term *kshetra-patni* ("mistress of the field") originate?

- (A) Rig Veda
- (B) Atharva Veda
- (C) Ashtadhyayi
- (D) Arthashastra

- **PROVISIONAL LOCAL SERIES-A KEY: B - Atharva Veda**

- **Explanation:** The audited local question/key route identifies the Atharva Veda. It must be distinguished from Rigvedic *kshetra-pati* ("lord of the field", RV 4.57). The two main history textbooks do not isolate *kshetra-patni*, so the local paper and provisional key control this narrow identification.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. *Kshetra-patni* - Atharva Veda; *kshetra-pati* - Rigvedic agricultural invocation.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Masculine and feminine forms are assumed to have the same textual origin.

CORRECT: Treat the exact lexical form tested by UPSC.

HIGH**Solved Mains PYQ - 2023 GS-I Q11****Prelims + GS-I**

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STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** What are the main features of Vedic society and religion? Do you think some of the features are still prevailing in Indian society? (Answer in 250 words)

- Demand

- The answer must identify social and religious features across the broad Vedic horizon, assess persistence rather than merely assert it, and avoid presenting early and later Vedic society as unchanged.

- Model answer

- Vedic society evolved from a predominantly kin-based agro-pastoral order toward a more settled, stratified and territorially organized world; its religious traditions likewise moved from hymnic sacrifice toward elaborate ritual and philosophical inquiry.

- Socially, the Rigvedic *jana-vis* framework, *rajan* as chief and assemblies such as *sabha* and *samiti* show authority embedded in kinship. Cattle wealth, gift exchange and household production dominated, although wells, ploughing and crafts prove that agriculture was present. By the Later Vedic phase, Kuru-Panchala settlements, agrarian surplus and PGW/iron contexts supported stronger kingship and occupational differentiation. The later *Purusha Sukta* and Brahmana texts articulate varna hierarchy, but their normative scheme cannot be projected uniformly onto all regions.

- Religiously, Rigvedic hymns invoke Indra, Agni, Soma and Varuna through *yajna*. The Vedic oral tradition preserved precise metres and ritual formulae; later *rajasuya*, *vajapeya* and *ashvamedha* linked sacrifice to sovereignty. Upanishadic reflection on *brahman*, *atman* and knowledge emerged within, not outside, this tradition.

- Continuities survive in recitation traditions, fire rituals, marriage/death rites, sacred vocabulary and philosophical concepts. Yet present Hindu society also reflects shramana, devotional, regional, tribal, Islamic, Sikh, Christian and modern constitutional influences. Caste practices are historical transformations, not an unchanged Rigvedic fossil.

- Thus, Vedic legacies are real but selective, reinterpreted and layered rather than timeless replicas.

- Why this earns marks

- It answers both features and persistence, distinguishes Rig and Later Vedic phases, uses six named evidence units, treats texts as normative sources, and gives a graded continuity-with-transformation conclusion.

HIGH

Solved Mains PYQ - 2024 GS-I Q1

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STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Underline the changes in the field of society and economy from the Rig Vedic to the later Vedic period. (Answer in 150 words)

- Demand

- "Underline changes" requires a direct comparative structure focused on society and economy, with continuities preventing a crude rupture story.

- Model answer

- The transition was from a cattle-valued, kin-based and relatively mobile order toward a more settled agrarian, territorial and stratified society.

- In the Rigvedic family books, cattle were the principal measure of wealth; *gavishti* linked war to cattle raids, while ploughing, wells and harvesting show that agriculture already existed. Production was organized largely through households and clans, and booty, gifts and voluntary *bali* supported the *rajan* and priests. In the Later Vedic Kuru-Panchala zone, stable settlements, two-crop agriculture and iron/PGW contexts enlarged surplus; *bali* became more obligatory and crafts became more differentiated. Archaeology supports broad change but PGW cannot be equated with every Vedic group.

- Socially, the *jana-vis* order and plural assemblies gave way gradually to *janapada*, stronger hereditary kingship and expanded ritual specialists. Early differentiation hardened into a more explicit varna hierarchy, while later texts indicate stronger patriarchal restrictions.

- Pastoralism, kinship and sacrifice continued. Hence the change was cumulative agrarian territorialization, not an overnight revolution.

- Why this earns marks

- It remains within the two tested dimensions, supplies Rigvedic and Later Vedic evidence, uses a compact comparison, adds PGW source caution and concludes with change plus continuity.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 1 - Q1

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q1. Which is the most defensible primary meaning of "Indo-Aryan" in historical reconstruction?**

- - (A) A subgroup of Indo-Iranian languages and, cautiously, its speakers
- - (B) A biological race identifiable by skull form
- - (C) A pottery tradition
- - (D) A modern political nationality

- **Answer: A**

- **Explanation:** Indo-Aryan is fundamentally a linguistic category. It may be used cautiously for speech communities, never as a biological essence.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 1 - Q2

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- **Q2. Why is the Aryan problem fundamentally interdisciplinary?**

- - (A) Linguistics alone has no regular method
- - (B) Each evidence class answers different questions and has distinct limitations
- - (C) Archaeology directly records spoken language
- - (D) Genetics supplies ancient political names

- **Answer: B**

- **Explanation:** Linguistics, text, archaeology, genetics, ecology and historiography concern different objects; their convergence must be demonstrated.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 1 - Q3

Prelims + GS-I
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STATIC THEORY

- Q3. Which statement best describes the old invasion model?

- - (A) It is confirmed by a uniform Harappan destruction horizon
- - (B) It is identical to every migration model
- - (C) Its simplistic conquest-destruction formulation is rejected
- - (D) It is proven by Cemetery-H pottery

- Answer: C

- **Explanation:** Harappan decline is earlier, regional and multi-causal; there is no uniform battle layer linked to Aryan conquest.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 1 - Q4

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q4. Which inference is invalid?

- - (A) Language can spread without total population replacement
- - (B) Pottery can move through exchange and imitation
- - (C) Ancient DNA can reveal biological ancestry
- - (D) A Steppe-related ancestry component directly identifies Vedic Sanskrit

- Answer: D

- **Explanation:** Ancestry and language are different variables; association requires independent chronology and linguistics.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 2 - Q5

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- **Q5. Comparative linguistics identifies language relationship most securely through**

- - (A) regular sound correspondences and shared morphology
- - (B) any two similar-looking words
- - (C) modern racial appearance
- - (D) identical pottery

- **Answer: A**

- **Explanation:** Systematic correspondences across core vocabulary and grammar are much stronger than accidental resemblance.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 2 - Q6

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- **Q6. Vedic *soma* and Avestan *haoma* primarily support**

- - (A) identity of every Vedic and Iranian ritual
- - (B) a shared Indo-Iranian linguistic-cultural inheritance
- - (C) a Harappan decipherment
- - (D) direct migration from Iran in one year

- **Answer: B**

- **Explanation:** The cognate ritual term supports relationship; botanical identity, route and ritual detail remain debated.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 2 - Q7

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q7. Which claim best fits the Mitanni evidence?

- (A) All Mitanni subjects spoke Vedic Sanskrit
- (B) The Rig Veda was composed in Syria
- (C) Indo-Aryan divine and horse-training terms were present in a mid-second-millennium BCE Near Eastern elite milieu
- (D) Mitanni archaeology is identical to PGW

- Answer: C

- **Explanation:** The treaty and Kikkuli text provide external Indo-Aryan attestations, not a complete demographic or textual history.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 2 - Q8

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STATIC THEORY

- Q8. A major limitation of Mitanni evidence is that it cannot

- (A) provide a secure external chronology
- (B) show Indo-Aryan-sounding names
- (C) reveal horse-training vocabulary
- (D) directly date the composition of the Rig Veda

- Answer: D

- **Explanation:** Related words outside India do not date individual Rigvedic hymns.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 3 - Q9

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STATIC THEORY

- **Q9. Which feature most directly supports multilingual interaction in the Rigvedic world?**

- - (A) Non-Indo-European loanwords and names
- - (B) The existence of rivers
- - (C) Bronze use alone
- - (D) Oral metre alone

- **Answer: A**

- **Explanation:** Loanwords, non-Indo-Aryan names and areal phonological features show contact.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 3 - Q10

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q10. Retroflex consonants in Indo-Aryan are most safely used as evidence of**

- - (A) a pure steppe language untouched by South Asia
- - (B) South Asian areal/contact influence, with chronology debated
- - (C) the Harappan script's decipherment
- - (D) a biological mutation

- **Answer: B**

- **Explanation:** Retroflexion is a linguistic contact/areal phenomenon, not a gene or script reading.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 3 - Q11

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q11. The presence of Arya chieftains with non-Indo-Aryan names suggests

- - (A) every chief was a foreigner
- - (B) names have no historical value
- - (C) porous boundaries and incorporation
- - (D) caste was fully fixed

- Answer: C

- Explanation: Name-language mismatch can reflect alliance, adoption, bilingualism or incorporation.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 3 - Q12

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q12. Which conclusion about loanwords is excessive?

- - (A) Contact occurred
- - (B) Multiple speech communities coexisted
- - (C) Cultural borrowing accompanied language formation
- - (D) Every institution in Vedic society was borrowed from one donor language

- Answer: D

- Explanation: Loanwords show contact but not total derivation of a culture.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 4 - Q13

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q13. Which books are conventionally called the older Rigvedic "family books"?

- - (A) Books 2-7
- - (B) Books 1 and 10 only
- - (C) All books are exactly simultaneous
- - (D) Only Book 9

- Answer: A

- Explanation: Books 2-7 are conventionally older, though old and new material can cross textual arrangements.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 4 - Q14

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STATIC THEORY

- Q14. Why should the Rig Veda not be read as a modern chronicle?

- - (A) It contains no geography
- - (B) It is a layered ritual-poetic corpus with elite authorship and oral compilation
- - (C) Oral traditions preserve nothing
- - (D) It has no social terms

- Answer: B

- Explanation: Genre, audience, layering and context constrain historical extraction.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 4 - Q15

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- **Q15.** The core geography of the Rigvedic family books is

- - (A) lower Krishna valley
- - (B) Magadha
- - (C) Sapta-Sindhu in the north-west
- - (D) Kaveri delta

- **Answer:** C

- **Explanation:** The Indus, tributaries and Sarasvati/Ghaggar-Hakra zone form the central textual geography.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 4 - Q16

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- **Q16.** Which river pair is incorrectly matched?

- - (A) Vitasta-Jhelum
- - (B) Asikni-Chenab
- - (C) Parushni-Ravi
- - (D) Yavyavati-Beas

- **Answer:** D

- **Explanation:** Beas is Vipasha; the 2026 PYQ uses Yavyavati as a trap.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 5 - Q17

Prelims + GS-I
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STATIC THEORY

- Q17. The safest description of the early Vedic economy is

- - (A) agro-pastoral with pastoral values and cattle-centred wealth
- - (B) wholly nomadic with no agriculture
- - (C) urban and coin-based
- - (D) an iron-plough state economy

- Answer: A

- Explanation: Agriculture, wells and crafts were known, but cattle and pastoral mobility dominated elite values.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 5 - Q18

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q18. In early Vedic contexts, *ayas* should

- - (A) always be translated as steel
- - (B) not automatically be equated with iron
- - (C) prove PGW identity
- - (D) be ignored

- Answer: B

- Explanation: Early material contexts are primarily copper/bronze; iron becomes defining later.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 5 - Q19

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q19.** The term *gavishti* is valuable because it links

- - (A) temples and taxation
- - (B) cities and writing
- - (C) cattle wealth with conflict
- - (D) iron and coinage

- **Answer: C**

- **Explanation:** Cattle raids and warfare reveal how economy shaped political prestige.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 5 - Q20

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q20.** Which statement about the horse is most accurate?

- - (A) It was absent from all South Asian contexts
- - (B) It proves race
- - (C) It was more important than cattle in every household
- - (D) It had strong elite, ritual and martial importance, while archaeological frequency is uneven

- **Answer: D**

- **Explanation:** Textual prominence and material prevalence are related but not identical.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 6 - Q21

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q21. The *rajan* of the early Vedic world is best understood as

- - (A) a kin-based chief and war leader
- - (B) a Mauryan-style emperor
- - (C) an elected modern president
- - (D) a city mayor

- Answer: A

- Explanation: Authority depended on kinship, war, ritual and redistribution rather than a territorial bureaucracy.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 6 - Q22

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q22. Which statement about *sabha* and *samiti* is safest?

- - (A) They had identical, fully known functions
- - (B) They were assemblies whose composition and exact powers remain debated
- - (C) They were universal adult-franchise bodies
- - (D) They prove a republican constitution

- Answer: B

- Explanation: The terms show collective institutions, but their membership and authority are uncertain.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 6 - Q23

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q23. The Battle of Ten Kings is most useful as evidence for

- - (A) a Harappan municipal war
- - (B) a Magadhan empire
- - (C) tribal confederacy, cattle-war prestige and shifting alliances
- - (D) Greek invasion

- Answer: C

- Explanation: Book 7 places Sudas and the Bharatas in a competitive tribal landscape.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 6 - Q24

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q24. Which early Vedic fiscal claim is incorrect?

- - (A) Gifts and booty mattered
- - (B) *Bali* existed in an emerging redistributive context
- - (C) Chiefs depended on ritual and generosity
- - (D) A standardized territorial tax bureaucracy was fully developed

- Answer: D

- Explanation: Regular fiscal administration is a later development.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 7 - Q25

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q25. Which archaeological formulation is methodologically correct?

- - (A) Cemetery H shows mortuary transformation with continuity and change
- - (B) Cemetery H directly records Sanskrit speech
- - (C) Every urn burial is Vedic
- - (D) Pottery motifs prove a named doctrine

- Answer: A

- Explanation: Burial and pottery can reveal changing practice; language and doctrine require additional evidence.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 7 - Q26

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q26. Gandhara Grave/Swat is best treated as

- - (A) a single-year invasion camp
- - (B) a long-lived frontier interaction zone with varied burials and material
- - (C) a Mature Harappan city system
- - (D) a direct synonym for Indo-Aryan

- Answer: B

- Explanation: Its broad chronology and mixed practices resist a one-event ethnic label.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 7 - Q27

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q27. Which statement about OCP and Copper Hoards is correct?

- - (A) All objects were discovered in secure graves
- - (B) OCP always immediately precedes PGW
- - (C) Regional sequences and poor contexts make ethnic attribution unsafe
- - (D) Antennae swords prove one migrating tribe

- Answer: C

- Explanation: OCP relations vary by site, and many copper hoards lack secure stratigraphy.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 7 - Q28

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q28. Which mapping is least defensible?

- - (A) PGW with some Later Vedic/early Iron Age contexts
- - (B) Late Harappan with localization
- - (C) Swat with frontier interaction
- - (D) One pottery style with one language and ethnicity

- Answer: D

- Explanation: Material culture and speech communities cannot be equated mechanically.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 8 - Q29

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q29. Which statement about PGW is correct?

- - (A) It is often a fine ware forming a small part of the pottery assemblage
- - (B) It defines the Mature Harappan phase
- - (C) Every PGW site has iron
- - (D) It is identical with the Rig Veda

- Answer: A

- Explanation: PGW is a technically fine, often restricted ware found with other everyday ceramics.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 8 - Q30

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q30. Bhagwanpura is important because it shows

- - (A) a Greek colony
- - (B) overlap between Late Harappan and PGW, with phase cautions
- - (C) a deciphered Vedic inscription
- - (D) a uniform destruction layer

- Answer: B

- Explanation: Overlap allows a transition/contact question but not an identity equation.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 8 - Q31

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q31. Which feature of Sanauli is secure?

- - (A) Horse DNA from every vehicle
- - (B) Spoked wheels
- - (C) Two-wheeled solid-wheel vehicles with poles/yokes
- - (D) A Vedic inscription

- Answer: C

- Explanation: The vehicles are real; horse traction and Sintashta-style chariot identity are not established.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 8 - Q32

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q32. Which conclusion from Sanauli is invalid?

- - (A) The burials show wealth and distinctive mortuary practice
- - (B) They have Late Harappan affinities
- - (C) They raise interaction questions
- - (D) They settle Indo-Aryan migration and Vedic identity

- Answer: D

- Explanation: A single spectacular site cannot settle a multi-evidence language-population debate.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 9 - Q33

Prelims + GS-I
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STATIC THEORY

- Q33. BMAC is best understood as

- (A) an oasis-centred interaction zone linked to steppe and southern networks
- (B) one Vedic tribe
- (C) a PGW settlement
- (D) a modern genetic cluster

- Answer: A

- Explanation: BMAC societies were complex oasis communities interacting with mobile and settled populations.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 9 - Q34

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q34. Which statement about Sintashta is most defensible?

- (A) It directly proves every Rigvedic verse
- (B) It provides early spoked-wheel chariot and horse-burial contexts relevant to Indo-Iranian hypotheses
- (C) It was a Harappan city
- (D) It eliminates BMAC interaction

- Answer: B

- Explanation: The convergence is important but culture-language identity remains an inference.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 9 - Q35

Prelims + GS-I
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STATIC THEORY

- Q35. Heggarty et al. 2023 proposed

- - (A) an out-of-India model accepted unanimously

- - (B) no language family relationship

- - (C) a hybrid Indo-European homeland model with an ultimate south-Caucasus and secondary steppe component

- - (D) that genes are languages

- Answer: C

- Explanation: The study used a new phylogeny; its dates and archaeological alignment remain debated.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 9 - Q36

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q36. Which is the proper use of the 2024 *Antiquity* review?

- - (A) Treat it as an ancient DNA dataset

- - (B) Use it to assign Harappan language

- - (C) Use it as final proof of one homeland

- - (D) Use it to show both the promise and limits of interdisciplinary triangulation

- Answer: D

- Explanation: The review evaluates integration, gaps and disagreements rather than closing the debate.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 10 - Q37

Prelims + GS-I
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STATIC THEORY

- Q37. The 2019 Rakhigarhi genome most securely establishes that

- (A) the sampled Harappan individual lacked detectable Steppe pastoralist ancestry
- (B) no later population movement occurred
- (C) the Harappan language was Sanskrit
- (D) all Harappans had identical ancestry

- Answer: A

- Explanation: One individual constrains the sampled profile and timing; it cannot represent the whole civilization or later history.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 10 - Q38

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q38. Narasimhan et al. 2019 is especially important because it

- (A) deciphered the Harappan script
- (B) modelled ancient population movements and mixture across South and Central Asia
- (C) proved a single invasion
- (D) used only modern genomes

- Answer: B

- Explanation: The study analysed 523 ancient individuals and documented regional ancestry change.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 10 - Q39

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
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STATIC THEORY

- Q39. Which statement correctly combines the two 2019 studies?

- - (A) Both identify an Aryan gene
- - (B) Both show no mobility
- - (C) Rakhigarhi constrains one Mature Harappan profile, while the wider study models later regional movements
- - (D) Both directly detect Sanskrit

- Answer: C

- Explanation: Their scales and samples differ, making them complementary rather than interchangeable.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 10 - Q40

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q40. Which is a misuse of ancient DNA?

- - (A) Testing biological relatedness
- - (B) Modelling admixture
- - (C) Comparing dated regional samples
- - (D) Assigning religion and language directly from ancestry

- Answer: D

- Explanation: Cultural and linguistic attribution requires other evidence.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 11 - Q41

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q41. Kerdoncuff et al. 2025 used

- - (A) 2,762 present-day whole genomes
- - (B) only one Harappan skeleton
- - (C) only mitochondrial DNA from Burzahom
- - (D) the Harappan script

- Answer: A

- Explanation: It is a large modern-genome study with biomedical and population-history implications.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 11 - Q42

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q42. The main limitation of using the 2025 Cell study for the Aryan question is

- - (A) it contains no DNA
- - (B) modern genomes include later drift, admixture and endogamy
- - (C) it has no Indian samples
- - (D) it predates archaeogenetics

- Answer: B

- Explanation: Modern samples are informative but not direct Bronze Age observations.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 11 - Q43

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q43. The Burzahom 2025 study recovered primarily

- - (A) a complete political archive
- - (B) a chariot burial genome
- - (C) ancient mitochondrial lineages from several periods
- - (D) the language of Kashmir

- Answer: C

- Explanation: Mitogenomes track maternal lineages and have limited population coverage.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 11 - Q44

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q44. Which statement about the 22 June 2026 Rakhigarhi development is correct?

- - (A) It published a final genome study
- - (B) It proved one homeland
- - (C) It was a linguistic survey
- - (D) It transferred remains for planned multidisciplinary analysis; results were pending

- Answer: D

- Explanation: Announced methods must not be converted into findings.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 12 - Q45

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q45. Which model currently has the strongest broad support?**

- - (A) Phased migration/in-migration combined with interaction and local continuity
- - (B) Violent invasion as sole cause of Harappan decline
- - (C) One-to-one PGW ethnicity
- - (D) Biological race replacement

- **Answer: A**- **Explanation:** Linguistics, archaeology and aDNA best fit mobility plus synthesis, with many micro-questions open.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 12 - Q46

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q46. Which is the strongest contribution of strict indigenous critiques?**

- - (A) Proving Harappan Sanskrit
- - (B) Insisting on continuity, local agency and criticism of colonial racialism
- - (C) Eliminating Mitanni evidence
- - (D) Showing genes equal culture

- **Answer: B**- **Explanation:** These concerns improve method even though maximal no-migration/OIT claims are weak.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 12 - Q47

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q47. "Interaction and synthesis" means

- - (A) no migration occurred
- - (B) conflict never occurred
- - (C) inherited Indo-Iranian elements were transformed through South Asian contact and continuity
- - (D) all cultures became identical

- Answer: C

- Explanation: The model combines mobility, borrowing, bilingualism, conflict and incorporation.

HIGH

Hard MCQ Learning Loop 12 - Q48

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q48. Which conclusion is best?

- - (A) The Aryan debate is wholly unknowable
- - (B) One discipline has solved everything
- - (C) Modern politics determines ancient facts
- - (D) Migration is the strongest macro-model, while the identity of early Vedic culture is best explained through interaction and synthesis

- Answer: D

- Explanation: This is a graded verdict matching different levels of evidence.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 1 - Q49

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q49. If a Harappan site has a fire installation, the safest conclusion is**

- - (A) ritual/fire use is possible, but Vedic identity requires further evidence
- - (B) the Rig Veda was written there
- - (C) the inhabitants spoke Sanskrit
- - (D) the structure is an *ashvamedha* altar

- **Answer: A**

- **Explanation:** Fire is widespread; context, form and chronology must be compared before naming a ritual.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 1 - Q50

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q50. If Steppe-related ancestry appears in a later sample, what follows most securely?**

- - (A) The sample recited the Rig Veda
- - (B) biological ancestry from populations related to the statistical reference entered that population history
- - (C) all local culture disappeared
- - (D) the person belonged to one modern caste

- **Answer: B**

- **Explanation:** Ancestry is the direct result; language, culture and social status are additional inferences.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 1 - Q51

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q51.** Which phrase best repairs the statement "PGW was the Aryan pottery"?

- - (A) PGW proves Aryan race
- - (B) PGW has no relevance
- - (C) PGW overlaps some Later Vedic/early Iron Age contexts but cannot identify a speech community alone
- - (D) PGW is Harappan script

- **Answer: C**

- **Explanation:** Correlation is useful when identity claims are withheld.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 1 - Q52

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q52.** The absence of a mass invasion horizon proves

- - (A) every population was static
- - (B) Harappans spoke Vedic Sanskrit
- - (C) no contact occurred
- - (D) only that the simplistic conquest-destruction model lacks archaeological support

- **Answer: D**

- **Explanation:** It does not answer every migration or language question.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 2 - Q53

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q53. Which statement distinguishes fact from inference?**

- - (A) Fact: the Sanauli vehicles have solid wheels; inference: their draught animals and cultural identity
- - (B) Fact: they were Rigvedic horse chariots
- - (C) Fact: they prove BMAC colonization
- - (D) Fact: their users spoke Sanskrit

- **Answer: A**- **Explanation:** Vehicle form is observed; traction and identity are unresolved.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 2 - Q54

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q54. Which use of the Rakhigarhi genome is correct?**

- - (A) It represents every Harappan
- - (B) It is one crucial sample that constrains Mature Harappan ancestry and later-mixture chronology
- - (C) It deciphers the script
- - (D) It disproves all movement

- **Answer: B**- **Explanation:** Its importance and limitation must be stated together.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 2 - Q55

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q55. Which formulation best describes *Dasa/Dasyu*?**

- (A) A fixed biological race
- (B) Always an indigenous farmer
- (C) Contextual opponents/outsideers whose linguistic, ritual or political identity varied
- (D) A modern ethnicity

- **Answer: C**- **Explanation:** The text even records Arya-Arya conflict, defeating a simple racial binary.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 2 - Q56

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q56. Which answer-writing sequence is weakest?**

- (A) Define terms
- (B) Separate evidence classes
- (C) Weigh models
- (D) List scholars without evidence or limitation

- **Answer: D**- **Explanation:** Names add value only when tied to method and evidence.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 3 - Q57

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q57. Which sentence is most accurate?

- - (A) Harappan demographic continuity can coexist with later language shift and admixture
- - (B) Continuity proves no migration
- - (C) Migration proves extinction
- - (D) Language shift requires genocide

- Answer: A

- Explanation: Population, language and institutions can have different continuity patterns.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 3 - Q58

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- Q58. Why is the 2026 Tyagi-Rai review useful?

- - (A) It provides a new Harappan genome
- - (B) It synthesizes South Asian aDNA progress, scarcity and methodological priorities
- - (C) It is an official answer key
- - (D) It identifies Vedic gods genetically

- Answer: B

- Explanation: It is a peer-reviewed field review, not a new ancient sample.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 3 - Q59

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q59. Which phrase best describes the early Vedic cultural profile?**

- - (A) Urban literate empire
- - (B) Purely nomadic race
- - (C) Linguistically Indo-Aryan, agro-pastoral, kin-based, orally transmitted and interaction-shaped
- - (D) PGW state with coins

- **Answer: C**- **Explanation:** It combines language, economy, polity, tradition and contact without racialization.

HIGH

Remedial MCQ Loop 3 - Q60

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Q60. The best final verdict is**

- - (A) "Nothing can be known"
- - (B) "Genes prove culture"
- - (C) "One pottery proves language"
- - (D) "Different evidence classes support phased mobility and synthesis, but exact routes, scales and identities remain open"

- **Answer: D**- **Explanation:** A graded conclusion is neither false certainty nor evasive agnosticism.

HIGH

Original Solved 10-Marker 1 - Aryan as Linguistic-Cultural Category

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Why is "Aryan" better treated as a linguistic-cultural category than a biological race? Explain in 150 words.

- Demand

- Explain the conceptual correction through named linguistic, historiographical and genetic evidence, while acknowledging contextual uses of *arya* in the Rig Veda.

- Model answer

- "Aryan" is historically useful only when its different meanings are separated.

- First, comparative linguistics places Vedic Sanskrit in the Indo-Aryan subgroup of Indo-Iranian through regular sound, grammatical and lexical correspondences, such as Vedic *soma* and Avestan *haoma*. This proves language relationship, not shared biological purity.

- Second, the Rigvedic composers used *arya* as a contextual self-description. The text records conflicts with Dasas/Dasyus but also Arya enemies, while non-Indo-Aryan names and loanwords show porous cultural boundaries. Hence textual categories cannot be fixed as races.

- Third, colonial scholarship fused language with racial typology, a move criticized by Thomas Trautmann and Upinder Singh. Modern population genetics reinforces the correction: Shinde et al. 2019, Narasimhan et al. 2019 and Kerdoncuff et al. 2025 reveal layered ancestry and mixture, not pure communities. Yet genes still cannot identify language.

- Therefore, "Indo-Aryan-speaking groups" is the defensible formulation; biological-racial usage is methodologically false and politically misleading.

- Why this earns marks

- It directly answers "why", uses linguistic, textual, historiographical and genetic evidence, states what each proves, and avoids replacing race with genetic determinism.

HIGH

Original Solved 10-Marker 2 - Mitanni Evidence

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Assess the significance of Mitanni evidence for the history of Indo-Aryan languages. Answer in 150 words.

- **Demand**

- Assess requires contribution plus limitations; it should not become a narrative of the Mitanni kingdom.

- **Model answer**

- Mitanni evidence is a secure external chronological anchor for Indo-Aryan, but not a date-stamp for the Rig Veda.

- The c. 1380 BCE Hittite-Mitanni treaty from Bogazkoy invokes forms corresponding to Indra, Mitra, Varuna and the Nasatyas. A horse-training text associated with Kikkuli uses numerals and technical vocabulary resembling Indo-Aryan. These attestations prove that Indo-Aryan linguistic and ritual elements existed in a Near Eastern elite/chariot milieu by the mid-second millennium BCE. They also strengthen the separation of Indo-Aryan from Iranian within a wider Indo-Iranian history.

- However, the majority Mitanni language was Hurrian; the Indic elements probably formed a restricted superstrate. The evidence does not prove mass Indo-Aryan settlement, direct movement from Mitanni to India, or composition of the Rig Veda in West Asia. Upinder Singh specifically cautions that the inscriptions cannot date the Rig Veda directly.

- Thus, Mitanni is powerful for linguistic chronology and dispersal, but limited for demographic routes and South Asian textual dating.

- **Why this earns marks**

- It uses two named records, explains their precise evidentiary value, and supplies three explicit limitations before a graded assessment.

HIGH

Original Solved 10-Marker 3 - PGW Correlation

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Why cannot Painted Grey Ware be equated mechanically with the Aryans? Discuss in 150 words.

- **Demand**

- The answer must explain archaeological-method limits while preserving PGW's legitimate chronological relevance.

- **Model answer**

- Painted Grey Ware is an archaeological assemblage, not a language label.

- PGW, mainly dated by Upinder Singh to c. 1200-500/400 BCE, is concentrated in the Indo-Gangetic divide and upper Ganga plain. Fine grey tableware, village housing, mixed agriculture and increasing iron use make it relevant to Later Vedic and early Iron Age transformations. At Bhagwanpura, Dadheri and other sites, PGW overlaps Late Harappan levels; elsewhere it follows Late Harappan, OCP or BRW after a break. This regional variability proves that PGW was not one migration horizon.

- Moreover, PGW often forms only 3-10 per cent of an assemblage and coexists with everyday wares. Some PGW sites lack iron, while pre-PGW levels elsewhere contain it. Pottery can spread through trade, imitation, marriage and craft mobility; it cannot reveal speech without inscriptions.

- Therefore, PGW is a useful material context for some Later Vedic developments, but equating it with "the Aryans" collapses chronology, region and identity into one unsafe label.

- **Why this earns marks**

- It provides chronology, stratigraphic examples, technical detail and the central language-material distinction within a compact 10-mark argument.

HIGH

Original Solved 15-Marker 1 - Evidence Classes

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** "The Aryan problem is a problem of method." Analyse with reference to major evidence classes. Answer in 250 words.

- **Demand**

- Analyse requires showing how evidence produces and limits claims, not merely listing sources.

- **Model answer**

- The Aryan problem persists because linguistics, texts, archaeology and genetics reconstruct different dimensions of an unwritten and unevenly documented transition.

- Comparative linguistics supplies the strongest relationship claim. Regular correspondences place Vedic Sanskrit within Indo-Aryan and Indo-Iranian; Mitanni divine names and Kikkuli's horse vocabulary securely attest Indo-Aryan outside India by the mid-second millennium BCE. Yet linguistics alone cannot identify genes, pottery or an exact route.

- Rigvedic philology locates the family books in Sapta-Sindhu and reveals cattle wealth, horses, *jana-vis*, *rajan*, assemblies and sacrifice. But the text is layered, elite, ritual-poetic and orally compiled; it is not a dated census or chronicle.

- Archaeology records Late Harappan localization, Cemetery-H mortuary change, Swat burials, OCP/Copper Hoards, PGW and Sanauli vehicles. These demonstrate continuity, contact and regional transformation. However, a solid wheel, urn burial or pottery style cannot reveal language.

- Archaeogenetics adds biological movement. The 2019 Rakhigarhi genome lacked Steppe ancestry in one Harappan individual; Narasimhan et al. documented later Steppe-related movements and mixture. Together they constrain chronology, but ancestry is not Sanskrit, religion or ethnicity.

- Ecology explains corridors and adaptation but cannot cause migration automatically; historiography exposes colonial racialization but does not decide the ancient event.

- Thus, the strongest method is triangulation: compare evidence from the same time and region, state what each proves, and conclude with phased mobility, local continuity and synthesis rather than a racial or pottery equation.

- Why this earns marks

- It analyses six evidence classes, uses seven named examples, gives a limitation for every class and answers the quotation with a clear methodological verdict.

HIGH

Original Solved 15-Marker 2 - Invasion, Migration and Interaction

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Distinguish between invasion, migration and interaction models in explaining Indo-Aryan entry and cultural formation. Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- Distinguish requires definitions, evidence, explanatory strengths and a ranked conclusion.

- Model answer

- The three models differ in scale, mechanism and the relationship they posit between newcomers and existing populations.

- The old invasion model imagines a rapid, armed conquest that destroyed Harappan cities and replaced their people. It drew on older readings of Rigvedic "fort-destroying", Mohenjo-daro skeletons and horse/chariot superiority. Archaeology rejects this causal package: Harappan decline began earlier, varied regionally, and lacks a uniform battle horizon; Cemetery H combines continuity with mortuary change.

- Migration/in-migration proposes repeated movement of Indo-Aryan-speaking groups through Central Asian and north-western corridors. Comparative Indo-Iranian linguistics, Mitanni attestations, Sintashta chariot contexts and Narasimhan et al.'s Steppe-related ancestry movements support the macro-model. Upinder Singh therefore favours relatively small series of migrations rather than a massive wave. Its unresolved issues are exact route, scale, gender composition and mode of language spread.

- Interaction explains cultural formation after and during mobility. Late Harappan populations persisted; Rigvedic loanwords, retroflexion and non-Indo-Aryan names demonstrate contact with Dravidian, Munda and other speakers. The Rakhigarhi genome shows major IVC-related ancestry, while later genomes show mixture. Yet "interaction" must specify conflict, bilingualism, marriage, exchange and elite networks rather than become a vague compromise.

- Consequently, invasion is rejected, migration is the strongest explanation for language dispersal, and interaction/synthesis best explains the early Vedic culture that emerged in South Asia.

- Why this earns marks

- It defines and evaluates all three models, links each to named evidence, states unresolved variables and produces a ranked rather than artificially neutral conclusion.

HIGH

Original Solved 15-Marker 3 - Harappan-to-Vedic Relationship

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Examine the relationship between Harappan/post-Harappan populations and early Vedic culture without assuming either total replacement or complete identity. Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- Examine requires evidence for difference, continuity and contact, followed by a qualified model.

- Model answer

- The Harappan-to-Vedic transition combined institutional discontinuity, substantial population continuity and later linguistic-cultural interaction.

- Difference is clearest between Mature Harappan cities (c. 2600-1900 BCE) and the conventional Rigvedic horizon (c. 1500/1200-1000 BCE). Harappan urbanism used script, standard weights, planned drainage and long craft networks; the Rigvedic family books describe an orally transmitted, cattle-valued agro-pastoral and kin-based world. Harappan carts generally had solid wheels, whereas spoked chariots dominate Vedic elite imagery. These contrasts make simple Harappan = Vedic identity unsafe.

- Continuity is equally important. Late Harappan Jhukar, Cemetery H, Hulas, Bhagwanpura and regional settlements preserve crops, pottery, crafts and population while cities, seals and standards decline. The Shinde et al. Rakhigarhi genome and wider IVC-related ancestry in later South Asians rule out demographic disappearance, although one genome cannot represent every Harappan region.

- Contact and mobility explain the new synthesis. Narasimhan et al. document later Steppe-related movements; Rigvedic Dravidian/Munda loanwords, retroflexion and non-Indo-Aryan names indicate multilingual interaction. PGW overlap with Late Harappan at selected sites provides material contact, but pottery cannot identify language.

- Therefore, neither replacement nor identity fits. A stronger model combines post-Harappan continuity, phased Indo-Aryan language dispersal, admixture and regional cultural synthesis.

- Why this earns marks

- It uses chronology, material culture, five sites, two genetic studies and contact linguistics, with a limitation attached to every identity claim.

HIGH

Original Solved 20-Marker 1 - Archaeogenetics and the Aryan Debate

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Critically evaluate how archaeogenetics has changed the Aryan debate without resolving it completely. Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- Critically evaluate requires contribution, major studies, methodological limits and a reasoned verdict on what has and has not changed.

- Model answer

- Archaeogenetics has transformed the Aryan debate from speculative race typology into testable ancestry history, but it cannot directly reconstruct language or culture.

- Its first contribution is chronological separation. Shinde et al.'s 2019 Rakhigarhi genome lacked detectable Steppe-pastoralist ancestry and immediate Anatolian/Iranian-farmer ancestry in one Mature Harappan individual. This constrains claims that Steppe-related ancestry was already ubiquitous in the Harappan core; however, one individual cannot represent a civilization spanning centuries and regions.

- Second, Narasimhan et al.'s 523 ancient genomes documented Bronze Age movements across Central Asia and later Steppe-related ancestry in northern South Asian populations. Combined with Indo-Iranian linguistics and Mitanni/Sintashta chronology, this strengthens phased post-Harappan migration. Yet "consistent with language spread" remains inference, because genomes do not encode Sanskrit.

- Third, Kerdoncuff et al. 2025 used 2,762 modern Indian genomes to refine mixture, drift and endogamy histories. Its breadth counters purity narratives, but modern samples integrate millennia of later change. Dwivedi et al.'s 2025 Burzahom mitogenomes add rare direct Kashmir evidence, while tracking only maternal lineages.

- Methodological limits remain severe: hot-climate preservation, small and elite-biased cemeteries, contamination, uneven geography, statistical reference choices and ethical permissions. The 2026 Tyagi-Rai review and new Rakhigarhi sampling underline the need for transitional-period datasets; announced analysis is not a result.

- Thus, aDNA strongly supports mobility plus continuity and rejects racial replacement. It revises probabilities and dates, but language, institutions and identity still require linguistics, texts and archaeology.

- Why this earns marks

- It evaluates four studies and one review, distinguishes ancient from modern and mitochondrial evidence, lists methodological limits and ends with a precise "changed but not resolved" verdict.

HIGH

Original Solved 20-Marker 2 - Indigenous and Migration Positions

Prelims + GS-I
Ancient History
07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Evaluate the migration and indigenous/out-of-India positions in the Aryan debate. How far does an interaction model offer a better explanation? Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- The three-part question requires fair representation, proportional evaluation and a final comparison with interaction.

- Model answer

- The migration and indigenous positions preserve different valid insights, but their maximal forms are not equally supported.

- Migration theory argues that Indo-Aryan-speaking groups entered South Asia in phases. Comparative linguistics places Vedic within Indo-Iranian; the c. 1380 BCE Mitanni treaty supplies external Indo-Aryan attestation; Sintashta provides an early chariot context; and Narasimhan et al. 2019 document later Steppe-related movements into northern South Asia. These convergences make migration the strongest macro-model. Its weaknesses concern exact route, numbers and the mechanism of language shift; they do not justify reviving invasion.

- Indigenous/out-of-India arguments rightly stress Harappan-to-Late Harappan continuity, uncertain textual dates, the absence of an invasion horizon and colonial misuse of Aryan race theory. However, strict Harappan = Vedic or outward-only dispersal must explain material differences between urban Harappan and early Vedic worlds, external Mitanni chronology, Indo-European branching, South Asian contact features such as retroflexion, and post-Harappan Steppe-related admixture. No Harappan text securely identifies its language.

- Interaction offers the best cultural explanation when joined to migration. Late Harappan populations and IVC-related ancestry persisted; Rigvedic loanwords, non-Indo-Aryan names and areal phonology show bilingual contact; BMAC and Swat illustrate corridors rather than sealed peoples. This model allows conflict and unequal language spread without total replacement.

- Therefore, migration best explains Indo-Aryan dispersal, indigenous critiques preserve continuity and agency, and interaction/synthesis best explains the historical identity formed in South Asia.

- Why this earns marks

- It gives both positions their strongest evidence, tests rather than caricatures them, uses eight named evidence units and answers how far interaction improves the explanation.

HIGH

Original Solved 20-Marker 3 - Identity of Aryan Culture

Prelims + GS-I

Ancient History

07

STATIC THEORY

- **Question:** Reconstruct the identity of early Vedic or "Aryan" culture while explaining the limits of linking language, archaeology and ancestry. Answer in 250 words.

- Demand

- Reconstruct requires a positive cultural profile; the second clause demands a methodological firewall against one-to-one mapping.

- Model answer

- Early Vedic "Aryan" identity was primarily linguistic and ritual, embedded in an agro-pastoral, kin-based and increasingly stratified society.

- The Rigvedic family books use an early Indo-Aryan language within the Indo-Iranian branch. Oral hymns and sacrifice organized memory; Indra, Agni, Soma and Varuna connected war, fire, sacred drink and sovereignty. Mitanni divine names and Avestan parallels prove wider Indo-Aryan/Indo-Iranian relationships, but not identical societies.

- Economically, cattle were wealth and the object of *gavishti*, while horses and chariots carried elite martial prestige. Ploughing, wells, harvesting, weaving, carpentry and metalwork show an agro-pastoral mixed economy rather than pure nomadism. Politically, *jana*, *vis*, lineage and household framed production; the *rajan*, *purohita*, *senani* and assemblies operated without a mature territorial bureaucracy. Social hierarchy was emerging, but later varna rigidity cannot be projected onto all early layers.

- This identity was formed through interaction. Non-Indo-Aryan loanwords, names and retroflexion indicate contact with South Asian speech communities. Late Harappan populations and IVC-related ancestry persisted while later Steppe-related ancestry entered and mixed.

- The mapping limits are decisive: PGW, Cemetery H, Swat burials, Sanauli vehicles, BMAC and Sintashta illuminate contexts but cannot individually reveal language; aDNA reveals ancestry but not hymn, deity or polity.

- Thus, early Vedic culture was a portable Indo-Aryan linguistic-ritual tradition transformed through mobility and South Asian synthesis, not a biologically bounded race or one archaeological assemblage.

- Why this earns marks

- It delivers a complete economy-polity-society-religion-language profile, uses eight named evidence units, and repeatedly states what archaeology and genetics cannot prove.

End of Register Notes - UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI